

Halogen Group

This group of elements is made up of highly reactive members, which are called halogens. The word “halogen” means “salt former”, alluding to how these elements react with metals to form salts. The halogen group is mostly made up of non-metals, with the rare radioactive member astatine being classified as a semi-metal.



Halite, the mineral form of sodium chloride

Forming salts

In chemistry, a salt is a stable chemical compound made by an acid. Many common salts in nature include one of the halogens, often bonded to metal atoms. The most famous salt of all is sodium chloride, a compound of chlorine used in food. Its mineral is called halite, or simply “salt”.

Essential diet

Most of the halogens, which can be found in small amounts in food, are very important for good health. Chlorine and iodine especially have many uses in the body’s chemical processes. Compounds of fluorine are added to toothpaste and water to keep teeth strong. Astatine is the only halogen not found in the body.

